

ESCALATING TENSIONS

- On the G20 sidelines, PM Narendra Modi called out the continuing anti-India activities by "extremist elements" on Canadian soil, while Justin Trudeau alleged "foreign interference" in Canada's internal matters
- On Sept. 18, Trudeau hinted at a link between "agents" of Indian government and the killing of Hardeep Nijjar, a wanted pro-Khalistan terrorist, in Canada in June
- Canada even expelled a top Indian diplomat, inviting a tit-for-tat move from India, which has also rejected Trudeau's allegations as "unsubstantiated"

and their growing nexus with Sikh militants. Of the 28 notorious gangsters with an active imprint in north India, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) says, 25 call the shots from overseas. If the US has five of them, Canada accounts for nine—among them Goldy Brar, who moved in on a student visa five years ago, and is accused of ordering the hit on singer Sidhu Moosewala. The web of crime extends to drug smuggling and human trafficking from India, an issue Modi is said to have raised with Trudeau. Nijjar was suspected of having enlisted such gangsters to carry out targeted killings in Punjab, including that of RSS leader Jagdish Gagneja in Jalandhar in 2016. Indian agencies believe Canada's liberal gun laws, easy availability of sophisticated weapons and vast tracts of forest land facilitate armed training for apprentice militants. Pannu, a lawyer, helps "anti-India elements" get political asylum. "Keeping the Khalistan bogey alive helps him," says former Punjab DGP Shashi Kant. All these are concerns India has often flagged, to no avail.

The diplomatic spat has also derailed ongoing trade talks. In September first week, Canada abruptly paused negotiations on the Early Progress Trade Agreement (EPTA) with India. A prelude to a comprehensive trade deal, it was a key component of Canada's Indo-Pacific strategy that had termed India as a "critical partner". Milewski believes Trudeau has compromised the country's larger economic agenda to accommodate the Khalistan agenda. "Trudeau is playing to the gallery," he says, "and wants to show that he stood up to Modi for the sake of pro-Khalistani elements. But at what cost?" Scott Moe, premier of Saskatchewan province, which makes for roughly a third of Canada's exports to India, has accused Trudeau of damaging bilateral ties and keeping the provinces in the dark about the stalled trade talks.

Even top Canadian business executives who talked to INDIA TODAY argue that it's Canada—recording a below 2 per cent growth—that needs India, and not the other way round. India, which remains the fastest-growing major economy, is actively pursuing trade deals with the US, UK, EU and Australia. The Canadian businessmen fear that if Trudeau fails to normalise relations, they could miss the boat. The Khalistan issue aside, the two countries share a cordial people-to-people contact, with Canadian universities remaining a major draw for Indian students. India also features among Canada's top 10 trade partners. It's, thus, imperative that the two democracies find common ground. ■

UTTAR PRADESH ASSEMBLY BYPOLL

THE GHOSI REVELATIONS

By Prashant Srivastava

The recent assembly bypoll loss in Ghosi in Mau district of Uttar Pradesh has come as a setback for the ruling BJP. Party candidate Dara Singh Chauhan, who was the sitting Samajwadi Party (SP) MLA before his flight to the BJP, lost to the candidate of his former party, Sudhakar Singh, by a fairly massive margin of 42,759 votes. More than the specifics of the case, it's the general truth they reveal that offers the party food for thought ahead of 2024. A likely delay in a planned cabinet expansion, flowing as a consequence, is also reflective of a certain introspective turn.

A minister in the first term of the Yogi Adityananth government, Chauhan had left to join the SP just before the 2022 assembly polls. But with the SP losing the big contest, he resigned his assembly membership and rejoined the BJP in July. A source in the BJP local unit says there was a backlash against Chauhan since he was "constantly changing loyalties". The other relevant fact is that Sudhakar, a former MLA, is a native of Ghosi.